



Positively Negative

Grade 3
Cut Paper



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Last Revised: June 2024

POSITIVELY NEGATIVE

Length: 60 Minutes

Number of docents: 1

Purpose: Students explore positive and negative space through observation of fine art and by sculpting a cut paper work of art. This lesson is inspired by the Japanese principle of NOTAN - the balance of light and dark and the interaction of positive/negative space.

Visual Arts Standards:

- Apply knowledge of available resources, tools, and technologies to investigate personal ideas through the art-making process. (3.VA:Cr1.2)
- Create personally satisfying artwork using a variety of artistic processes and materials. (3.VA:Cr2.1)
- Demonstrate an understanding of the safe and proficient use of materials, tools, and equipment for a variety of artistic processes. (3.VA:Cr2.2)
- Speculate about processes an artist uses to create a work of art. (3.VA:Re7.1)
- Determine messages communicated by an image. (3.VA:Re7.2)
- Interpret art by analyzing use of media to create subject matter, characteristics of form, and mood. (3.VA:Re8)
- Evaluate an artwork based on given criteria. (3.VA:Re9)

Unit Contains: Portfolio

Materials docent will bring per student:

- 9" x 9" square piece of construction paper in varying colors
- 4.5" x 4.5" piece of construction paper in varying colors
- Corner guide

Materials teacher will provide per student:

- Pencil
- Scissors
- Glue stick

Featured Works:

Cat Watching a Spider, date unknown
Rivers and Farms, 1996
Rubin's Vase, 1915
Sky and Water, 1938
Samples of Notan art

Oide Toko
Wayne Thiebaud
Edgar Rubin
M. C. Escher

Vocabulary:

Positive Space – objects that capture our attention or the subject in an artwork.

Negative Space – the space that surrounds objects in a piece of art. It is the unfilled space between and around objects.

Symmetry - when one half of an object is a mirror image of the other half.

Bird's Eye View - objects seen from an aerial, overhead view.

Complementary color pairs - one primary and the secondary color across from it on the color wheel. When paired together, they appear brighter, when mixed together they appear brown or grey.

Warm colors - orange, red and yellow, remind us of things in nature like the sun, fire and lava.

Cool colors - blue, green and purple, remind of us of things in nature like the ocean, trees and grass.

Shapes – **organic**, a natural or “blobby” shape, like a cloud, pond, or spilled milk.
geometric, examples are circle, oval, triangle, rectangle, square, and star.

INTRODUCTION: (15 minutes)

Display a few samples and refer to them.

Today we will be talking about positive and negative space and making cut paper designs based on the Japanese principle of NOTAN. We'll talk more about this in a minute, but first let's review the art elements.

Art elements are the tools an artist uses to tell a story. Let's use these vocabulary words when observing the artwork we see today.

Today we are focusing on **SPACE** and how artists use space in their work.

ART ELEMENTS

LINE:
Direction: horizontal vertical diagonal
Quality: Curvy, straight,
Thick, Thin

SHAPE: Geometric, Organic

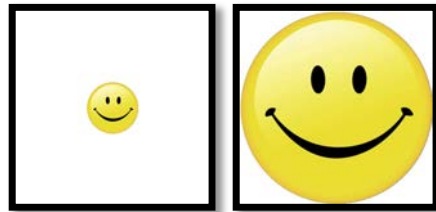
TEXTURE: ROUGH, Smooth, etc.

COLOR: HUE, **PRIMARY**,
SECONDARY,
Complementary pairs,
WARM or **COOL**, **VALUE**

SPACE: **POSITIVE** (filled) &
NEGATIVE (unfilled),
Perspective/Depth (fore, middle

How have I used space in these two drawings? (*Show smiley face poster or draw on board*)

How does the impact of the picture with the small face differ from the impact of the picture with the large face? (far vs. near, timid vs. bold, weak vs. powerful, calm vs. active)



The smiley face in each picture is where our attention is drawn – we call that the “Positive Space”. What do you think we call the space surrounding the positive space? (Negative Space)

Let's take a look at some paintings to see how artists used positive and negative space in their work.

CAT WATCHING A SPIDER, date unknown
Ôide Tôkô
Album leaf, ink and color on silk
14" x 11"

What is happening in this painting?

What objects capture your attention? (*The cat, spider, lines of the door which seem to draw your attention to what may be happening*).



Where are the positive spaces? (*cat, spider, door frame*)

Where are the negative spaces? (*ground, wall*)

Why do you think the artist, Toko, left so much empty NEGATIVE space? (*He wanted you to focus on the subject of the painting without any distraction*)

What do you think will happen next? What country do you think this painting is from: (*Japan, notice the chop –signature and the design in the scarf*).

RIVER AND FARMS, 1996
Wayne Thiebaud
Oil on Canvas
60" x 48"

What do you see in this painting? (*farm, crops, river*)

Where is the positive space in this painting? (*colorful farmland, filled space*) **Where is the negative space** (*the river, empty space that makes the farmland stand out*).



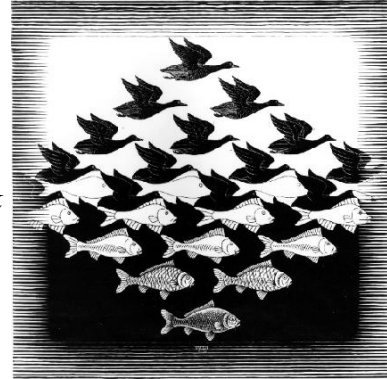
Where is the viewer in this painting? (*Overhead, bird's eye view*)

***SKY AND WATER I*, 1938**

M. C. Escher

Woodcut on Japan paper

17-¹/₄" x 17-¹/₄"



What do you see in this painting? (birds, fish, lots of black and white)

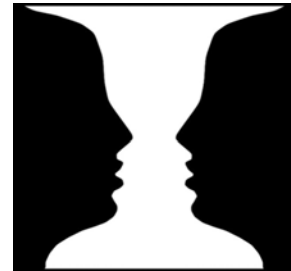
Which is the positive space? Negative space? On the top the black birds appear to be the subject of the painting, but as you look down to the bottom it appears the white fish are the subject. The positive/negative space changes as does the subject. (You can cover first the bottom of the painting and then the top to show how the PN space changes).

In this print the black and white are equally balanced, one not dominating the other. In Japan, the word for this is NOTAN meaning an equal balance of dark and light.

***RUBIN'S VASE*, 1915**

Edgar Rubin

Illustration



What do you see? (vase or two faces) **Does anyone see anything else?** How would the positive and negative space be different if the vase was black and the faces were white?

ARTWORK INSTRUCTIONS: (use document camera so students can see)

Our artwork today will be inspired by the Japanese principle of NOTAN using cut paper techniques. **NOTAN** is a word that means dark/light representing **POSITIVE** space and **NEGATIVE** space. **The spaces are equal with neither space dominating the other.** (Refer to *SKY AND WATER*)

Show examples of the Notan principle:

- Black and white example
- Sample using colors of equal strength - one dark, one light. (complementary pairs, warm/cool pairs or black and white all work well).
- Refer to the color wheel

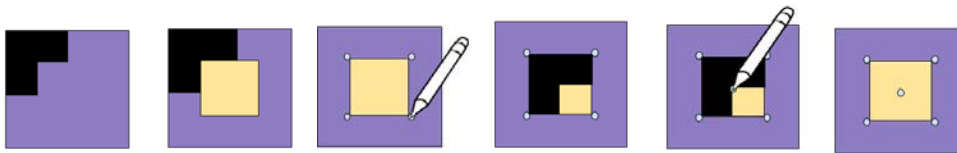
Have students select two contrasting colors so the artwork “pops”. (Refer to color wheel)

As students get paper, pass out one corner guide per student and have students get out scissors and pencil. (**WAIT** to pass out glue sticks if students do not already have them. If

students already have glue sticks ask them to put them in their desks so they won't be tempted to use them too soon.

Preparation: *(docent demonstrates and then has students complete each step as you go, put up poster of Prep)*

1. Put name on back of large paper, turn over.
2. Line up the corner guide on your large paper.
3. Place your small square inside it so your art will be centered.
4. Remove the corner guide and place a small dot on each corner outside of your small square, set aside.
5. Locate the center of the small square by lining up corner guide on your small square.
6. Put a small dot in the middle of the paper (It can be erased later).



Cut-outs: *(docent demonstrates and then has students complete)*

1. Cut out organic, geometric and/or symmetrical shapes on all four sides (*point to docent examples*).
2. **Take care not to cut past the center** of the paper. (*If you cut past the center of your paper, your cutout shape will end up going off the large paper in your completed composition, see notes below on ways to handle this.*)
3. Use your scissors to **sculpt your shapes**, turning your paper rather than your scissors.
4. **DO NOT cut off the corners** - go in and out of the same side when you cut out a shape.
5. Cut **one, two** or **three** shapes per side.

Placement of Paper and Gluing: *(docent demonstrates and then has students complete)*

1. Once your shapes are cut out, **place them back on the large square** like putting together a puzzle. Put an "X" on each cutout piece, that will be the side you glue down later.
2. Use the pencil dots as guidelines to center the small square again.
3. One by one, pick up a cut-out and turn it over "**X**" **side down** like opening a door placing it next to the cut-out location as a mirror image, touching your paper, but not overlapping. (*you can have students make a squeaky hinge noise, it helps them with the concept*).
4. When you have all of your pieces in place, raise your hand and we will come by to check them before you move on to the glue.

5. **Starting with the biggest center piece first**, glue pieces down one by one. Glue goes on the side with the “X”. (*docent to hand out glue sticks if students do not already have them*)
6. Continue to glue all of your cut-outs just outside of the small square, touching your original shape.

Note to docents: If a student has cut pieces that go past the center line, you can fit them on the large paper in a couple of ways:

- Don’t worry about being in the center of the page, slide the design so that it fits.
- Slightly overlap the cut-outs with the small shape to “cheat” a little more space.
- Turn the large paper 45 degrees so that it is like a diamond and place design.

REFLECTION:

As students finish up with the gluing, ask them to **rotate their art** to find the composition they like best and have them write their name on the back. Finally, ask students to share their work in front of the class.

- **What does your design look like to you? (animals? aliens? hearts?)**
- **Rotate your art, do you see something different?**
- **Did you have something in mind when you made your design or did it turn out differently?**
- **What would you like to name your art?**
- **After students share their art have them display them together along the board.**

Parent Instructions for Positively Negative

Thank you for volunteering today!

Please help by:

Setting up lesson supplies

- Clear desks/tables
- Fan papers out on back table for students to collect later
- If docent starts class on the carpet, put corner guides on desks
- Students will need pencil and scissors



During the lesson

- Listen carefully to the docent instructions to the students
- Assist individual students by walking around the room
- As students get the paper, pass out corner guides
- They will also need a pencil and scissors at this time
- Help students marking the center of large paper with corner template as needed
- Help students place all of their cut pieces on the outside of the main piece as a mirror image of that cut being careful not to lose any
- When students have all of their pieces cut and in place, confirm that they can move on to the gluing

Additional tips

- Please don't work on students' art — demonstrate on scrap materials
- Ask Art Docents if a student needs extra help
- Have fun!

Helping clean-up

- Collect corner guides and place in unit (after they are used)
- Wipe down tables as needed

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BACKGROUND

ÔIDE TÔKÔ 1841-1905 (Japanese)

We know very little about this artist, but his life falls nearly within the Meiji Era (1868-1912), which was one of rapid change for Japan. The Emperors had regained power following the overthrow of the Tokugawa shogunate in 1868 and used western models to reshape society. Some 3000 western experts—teachers, engineers and doctors—were brought into the country while thousands of Japanese students studied in the US. The rapid development of industry and the military led to the rise of Japan as a power in Asia.

Japanese art was split in two ways. Those artists upholding traditional values became known as Nihonga (Japanese style) while artists who assimilated new ideas were called Yōga (Western style).

Cat Watching a Spider, date unknown

Album leaf, ink and color on silk

14¾" x 11"

Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York

As *Cat Watching a Spider* was done on silk (which was more expensive than paper) for an album leaf, we presume it was not done for mass consumption but was targeted to the merchants and upper-middle class as a display of status. The subjects favored by the wealthy were seldom difficult to understand and were not spiritual in matter. Animals, in particular, were pictured in informal poses, such as the cat intensely studying the spider with humor, in anticipation of the next move. Hallmarks of the traditional Japanese style are: the bird's eye view, empty background, close study of detail and almost monochromatic use of color.

(MORTON) WAYNE THIEBAUD, b.1920 in Mesa, Arizona

Thiebaud worked in the animation department of Walt Disney Studios in LA as a teenager in 1936, and then spent a year studying commercial art at a trade school. He attended Long Beach Junior College, 1940-41 and served in the U.S. Air Force from 1942-45. From 1946-49 he worked as a layout designer and cartoonist for Rexall Drug Company in LA. He returned to school at San Jose State College in 1949-50 and earned a BA in 1951 and an MA in 1953 from California State College, Sacramento. From 1951-1960 he taught at Sacramento Junior College and was a faculty member at the University of California, Davis, from 1960-90.

The strong color in Thiebaud's works reflects the bright light of California where he continues to live and paint. He is known for the use of popular culture items including

pies and cakes, pinball and candy ball machines, hotdogs and beach balls; he also is known for landscapes, cityscapes, and figures. Thiebaud considers himself a still-life artist and the individual stroke of the artist's hand remains essential to his work.

***River and Farms*, 1996**

Oil on canvas

60 x 48 inches

Private collection of Nan Tucker McEvoy

Steven Nash writes, "The landscape fills the picture plane like a giant tapestry, with no horizon at the top for orientation or to help register...the extent of depth in the picture. A wide riverbed zigzags its way from top to bottom. ...To either side, brightly colored fields lock together in a syncopation of irregular shapes. That we aren't dealing here with a traditional Renaissance system of spatial organization and single- or-double-point perspective immediately hits home. Although we are led to feel that our bird's eye vantage point connects us visually with a long, flat vista, we sense that the whole composition tips up to the picture plane and that the many blocks of color are dipping and twisting in different directions, producing an optical landscape that is physically impossible to map. The many painted shadows imply at least two different positions for the sun."

M.C. ESCHER 1898 – 1972 (Dutch)

Maurits Cornelis Escher was born in Leeuwarden, Netherlands. Considered one of the world's most famous graphic artists, he is most recognized for spatial illusions, impossible buildings, repeating geometric patterns (called tessellations), and his techniques in woodcutting and lithography. Escher composed ironic works, often visual riddles that play with the pictorially logical and the visually impossible.

He was a man studied and greatly appreciated by respected mathematicians, scientists and crystallographers, yet he had no formal training in math or science. He was a humble man who considered himself neither an artist nor mathematician. Escher was a mediocre student, but showed obvious artistic talent early in his schooling. He was not encouraged to be an artist at a young age; his father hoped that he would learn carpentry and other craft skills. Later he was encouraged to pursue a career in architecture, but realized at the School of Architecture and Decorative Arts that his true passion was graphic art.

After completing his schooling, where he mastered graphics and 18 wood cutting techniques, he traveled extensively through Southern France, Spain and Italy. Throughout Escher's career, he was fascinated by the art of structure which is apparent in much of his work. His early work however, tended towards realistic portrayals of the landscape and architecture observed during his travels.

When Escher visited the Alhambra in Granada, he was captivated by the Moorish ornamentation that filled the entire space on walls. He became fascinated with repeated patterns, regular divisions of the plane, impossible constructions and infinite space.

During his lifetime, Escher made 448 lithographs, woodcuts and wood engravings and over 2,000 drawings and sketches. Apart from being a graphic artist, he illustrated books, designed tapestries, postage stamps and murals.

Like some of his famous predecessors, Michelangelo, Leonardo da Vinci, Durer and Holbein, Escher was left-handed. "I try in my prints to testify that we live in a beautiful and orderly world, not in chaos without norms, even though that is how it sometimes appears. My subjects are also often playful: I cannot refrain from demonstrating the nonsensicalness of some of what we take to be irrefutable certainties. It is, for example, a pleasure to deliberately mix together objects of two and of three dimensions, surface and spatial relationships, and to make fun of gravity

Sky and Water 1

woodcut, 1938

17-1/4" x 17-1/4"

In the horizontal central strip there are birds and fish equivalent to each other. We associate flying with the sky, and so for each of the black birds the sky in which it is flying is formed by the four white fish which encircle it.

Similarly swimming makes us think of water, and therefore the four black birds that surround the fish become the water in which it swims.

EDGAR RUBIN, 1886-1951 (Danish)

Born and raised in Copenhagen, Rubin studied psychology at the University of Copenhagen. Having specialized in figure-ground organization, Rubin spent 2 years as a research associate for Georg Elias Muller in Germany, examining the recognition of visual figures at different angles and sizes. His theories became influential within Gestalt psychology. In 1922, Rubin became Professor of Psychology at the University of Copenhagen, a position he held until his death.

***Rubin's Vase*, 1915 (sometimes known as the **Rubin Face** or the **Figure-ground vase**)** Illustration

The image was introduced in 1915, in Rubin's two-volume work, the Danish-language *Synsoplevede Figurer* ("Visual Figures"), which was very well-received; Rubin included a number of similar images, such as a black and white Maltese cross figure, but the one that became the most famous was the figure-ground vase (perhaps because the Maltese cross could also be easily interpreted as a black and white beach ball.)

The illusion generally presents the viewer with a mental choice of two interpretations, each of which is valid. One interpretation is of two black faces in the foreground with a

white background. The other is of a white vase in the foreground with a black background. Often, the viewer sees only one of the two valid interpretations, and only realizes the second after some time or prompting. When one attempts to simultaneously see the both interpretations, one finds that it is not possible to perceive both interpretations simultaneously, as one occludes the other.

Revision History

Revision Date	Docent Name	Comments
Spring 2018	Reneé Marshalla led committee	As part of the 5-year plan, emphasis was placed on art element of space (positive and negative space). Select prints from the “Space to Explore Art” lesson were added to enhance the discussion and introduction.
December 4, 2018	Reneé Marshalla	Instructions for gluing clarified.
May 2019	Kimberly Dickerson	New VAPA Standards added
June 2024	Curriculum Committee	Parent Volunteer Instructions Added